ACTS 2 DEVOTIONS

1 SAMUEL

April - July '26

Memory Verses

2 Corinthians 4:1	Therefore, having this ministry by the mercy of God, we do not lose heart.
2 Corinthians 4:2	But we have renounced disgraceful, underhanded ways. We refuse to practice cunning or to tamper with God's word, but by the open statement of the truth we would commend ourselves to everyone's conscience in the sight of God.
2 Corinthians 4:3-4	And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing. In their case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.
2 Corinthians 4:5	For what we proclaim is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake.
2 Corinthians 4:6	For God, who said, "Let light shine out of darkness," has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.
2 Corinthians 4:7	But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.
2 Corinthians 4:8	We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair;
2 Corinthians 4:9-10	persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed; always carrying in the body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our bodies.
2 Corinthians 4:11-12	For we who live are always being given over to death for Jesus' sake, so that the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our mortal flesh. So death is at work in us, but life in you.
2 Corinthians 4:13-14	Since we have the same spirit of faith according to what has been written, "I believed, and so I spoke," we also believe, and so we also speak, knowing that he who raised the Lord Jesus will raise us also with Jesus and bring us with you into his presence.

Memory Verses

2 Corinthians 4:15	For it is all for your sake, so that as grace extends to more and more people it may increase thanksgiving, to the glory of God.
2 Corinthians 4:16	So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day.
2 Corinthians 4:17-18	For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison, as we look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen. For the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.

Hymn of the Month

APRIL

In Christ Alone

In Christ alone my hope is found
He is my light, my strength, my song
This cornerstone, this solid ground
Firm through the fiercest drought and storm
What heights of love, what depths of peace
When fears are stilled, when strivings cease
My Comforter, my all in all
Here in the love of Christ I stand

There in the ground His body lay
Light of the world by darkness slain
Then bursting forth in glorious day
Up from the grave He rose again
And as He stands in victory
Sin's curse has lost its grip on me
For I am His and He is mine
Bought with the precious blood of Christ

No guilt in life, no fear in death
This is the power of Christ in me
From life's first cry to final breath
Jesus commands my destiny
No power of hell, no scheme of man
Can ever pluck me from His hand
'Til He returns or calls me home
Here in the power of Christ I'll stand

I find my strength, I find my hope
I find my help in Christ alone
When fear assails, when darkness falls
I find my peace in Christ alone
I give my life, I give my all
I sing this song to Christ alone
The King of kings, the Lord of all
All heaven sings to Christ alone
To Christ alone
To Christ alone

'Til He returns or calls me home
Here in the power of Christ I'll stand
Here in the power of Christ we stand

Authors: Keith Getty and Stuart Townend
Bridge: Kristian Stanfill

MAY

Jesus I My Cross Have Taken

Jesus, I my cross have taken,
All to leave, and follow Thee;
Destitute, despised, forsaken,
Thou from hence, my all shall be;
Perish ev'ry fond ambition,
All I've sought or hoped or known;
Yet how rich is my condition:
God and heav'n are still my own!

Let the world despise and leave me,
They have left my Savior, too;
Human hearts and looks deceive me,
Thou art not, like man, untrue;
And, while Thou shalt smiled upon me,
God of wisdom, love, and might,
Foes may hate, and friends may shun me:
Show Thy face, and all is bright.

Haste thee on from grace to glory,
Armed by faith, and winged by prayer;
Heav'n's eternal days before thee,
God's own hand shall guide thee there;
Soon shall close thy earthly mission,
Swift shall pass thy pilgrim days;
Hope shall change to glad fruition,
Faith to sight, and prayer to praise.

Author: Henry Francis Lyte
Composer: Attr. Wolfgang A. Mozart

Hymn of the Month

JUNE

Close to Thee

Thou my everlasting portion,
More than friend or life to me,
All along my pilgrim journey,
Savior, let me walk with Thee.
Close to Thee, close to Thee,
Close to Thee, close to Thee;
All along my pilgrim journey,
Savior, let me walk with Thee.

Not for ease or worldly pleasure,
Nor for fame my prayer shall be;
Gladly will I toil and suffer,
Only let me walk with Thee.
Close to Thee, close to Thee,
Close to Thee, close to Thee;
Gladly will I toil and suffer,
Only let me walk with Thee.

Lead me through the vale of shadows,
Bear me o'er life's fitful sea;
Then the gate of life eternal
May I enter, Lord, with Thee.
Close to Thee, close to Thee,
Close to Thee, close to Thee;
Then the gate of life eternal
May I enter, Lord, with Thee.

Author: Fanny Crosby
Composer: Silas J. Vail

JULY

Something For Thee (Savior, Thy Dying Love)

Savior, Thy dying love
Thou gavest me,
Nor should I aught withhold,
Dear Lord, from Thee;
In love my soul would bow,
My heart fulfill its vow,
Some off'ring bring Thee now,
Something for Thee.

At the blest mercy seat,
Pleading for me,
My feeble faith looks up,
Jesus, to Thee;
Help me the cross to bear,
Thy wondrous love declare,
Some song to raise, or pray'r,
Something for Thee.

Give me a faithful heart,
Likeness to Thee,
That each departing day
Henceforth may see
Some work of love begun,
Some deed of kindness done,
Some wand'rer sought and won,
Something for Thee.

All that I am and have,
Thy gifts so free,
In joy, in grief, through life,
Dear Lord, for Thee!
And when Thy face I see,
My ransom'd soul shall be,
Through all eternity,
Something for Thee.

Author: S. Dryden Phelps
Composer: Robert Lowry

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Monday, April 13, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 1:1-28 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

What are some lessons from this chapter about love, about prayer, and about vows?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, April 14, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 2:1-11 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- What are some recurring themes in Hannah's prayer about who God is?
- Given what she believes about God, it makes sense that Hannah would rejoice upon dedicating baby Samuel to the Lord. What do I believe about God, and how does this affect how I feel about giving my time, resources, and energies to serving him?

Tuesday, April 14, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 2:12-36 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 2:12-17

- Reflect on the brazen sinfulness of Eli's sons. What makes their sin much more than personal moral transgression?

1 Samuel 2:22-36

- Even though Eli had reprimanded his sons, God still holds him responsible for his sons' conduct. What lessons can I learn about fatherhood (parenthood) and about spiritual leadership?

1 Samuel 2:30, 35

- Reflect on what these verses show about the kind of person God is looking for.

Journal

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- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 3:1-14 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 3:1

- What can I learn from the fact that "the word of the LORD was rare" under Eli's leadership?

1 Samuel 3:9-12

- Reflect on the words: "Speak, for your servant hears."

1 Samuel 3:13-14

- God holds Eli responsible for "the iniquity he knew" but did not stop. What lessons about God-honoring relationships can I learn from this?

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

On Fridays we will memorize 2 Corinthians 4.

2 Corinthians 4:1 (ESV)

Therefore, having this ministry by the mercy of God, we do not lose heart.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 3:15-21 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 3:15-18

"Samuel is called to deliver a harsh message of judgment that is necessary if there is to be a hopeful new beginning for Israel in this trying time. [...] The call is to a prophetic task. [...] This text reminds us of the spiritual challenges and social transformations that God's call brings. We are urged not only to discern God's voice but to listen to what it asks of us as well. We are called to become the channel for God's prophetic word to our own time."[1]

- Are there any situations where I am tempted to hold back from telling the truth?
- Reflect on Eli's passivity regarding his sons and now God's impending judgment. What lessons are there for me regarding my relationship with God and with others?

1 Samuel 3:1, 19-21

"The chapter opens with the absence of God's word and ends with the proclamation of God's word through Samuel. The story opens with corrupt and discredited religious leadership in place and closes with new and vigorous leadership, recognized by all Israel. We are being prepared to recognize that, in the difficult days of social upheaval ahead for Israel, there is already a new beginning: God's initiative for new possibilities in spite of the failure and the passing away of old patterns."[2]

- During a very discouraging period in which the "word of the Lord was rare" (v.1) and the religious leaders were corrupt, how did Samuel's life bring God's presence back to Israel? Reflect on the importance of one person.

1 Bruce C. Birch, "The First and Second Book of Samuel," New Interpreter's Bible, *Vol. II (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1998) 994.*
2 Ibid.

Monday, April 20, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 4:1-11 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 4:1-5

"[The elders] were right in assuming that the Lord was responsible for their defeat, but wrong in thinking that a parade of the ark of the covenant would compensate for their neglect of the Lord's ethical demands. The 'ark' or 'chest' contained the very law of God to which Israel was committed under the covenant initiated by the Lord himself. To think that the presence of the ark with them would reverse their fortunes without any changes of heart in Israel's leaders was a measure of their insensitivity to spiritual things."[3]

- What are some ways in which people today might seek a sense of God's presence or blessing in inauthentic or impersonal ways while ignoring the real state of their heart before God?
- Why would people do this, and why would this be offensive to God?

1 Samuel 4:11

- What can I learn from the fact that God allowed "the ark of God" to be captured by the Philistines?

3 Joyce G. Baldwin, "1 & 2 Samuel," Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries *(Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1988), 69.*

Journal

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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 4:12-22 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Eli's sin as the spiritual leader of Israel wasn't that he did not know what was right and wrong. It was that he did not take action according to his beliefs—in short, his sin was passivity. Reflect on the tragic outcome of Eli's passivity. How was God's name dishonored? Who are the people who suffered the consequences of his passivity?
- What warnings or lessons are there for me?

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 5:1-6:12 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 5:1-8

"It must have disturbed a conquering people to discover their god bowing down before the ark of a vanquished people. Their instinct to prop their god back up is a natural one. It is not easy to relinquish an inadequate understanding of God. Even today when our little gods fall, our first instinct is not to abandon them but to prop them up again."[4]

- What assumptions about God and about Dagon were (or should have been) shattered by the events related in this passage?
- What can I learn about human nature from the fact that the Philistines' reaction to the supernatural events surrounding the ark was simply to avoid further contact by sending it away?

1 Samuel 5:7-6:9

- Despite the evidence that it was the hand of God, why would they still consider the possibility that "it happened to us by coincidence"?

4 Kenneth Chafin, Mastering the Old Testament: 1, 2 Samuel, *Word Publishing (1989), 59.*

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:2 (ESV)

But we have renounced disgraceful, underhanded ways. We refuse to practice cunning or to tamper with God's word, but by the open statement of the truth we would commend ourselves to everyone's conscience in the sight of God.

Friday, April 24, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 6:13-21 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

"Divine retribution continued to overtake those who misused the ark. This time some men of Beth Shemesh "looked into" the ark, a sin punishable by instant death (Nu 4:5, 20; 2 Sa 6:6-7). The mourners sensed that the ark symbolized the presence of a "holy God" (Lev 11:44-45), whose sanctity they could not approach. They therefore hoped he would depart from them."[5]

- Contrast the people's attitude in v. 13 versus v. 20. Are there ways I can relate to being ambivalent about God's presence in my life—wanting his blessing but not his holiness and standards?
- What lessons can I learn about what God is like and how to relate to him?

5 Zondervan NIV Study Bible. *Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2002.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
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Tuesday, April 28, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 7:1-17 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 7:3-6

- What are some components of repentance according to this passage?

1 Samuel 7:7-13

- Again, we see a biblical leader setting up a stone (v.12) as a memorial for what God had done. Reflect on your own "Ebenezer" times.
- What are some ways I can memorialize what God has done in my life?

1 Samuel 7:13-17

- Samuel continued to serve the people of Israel "all the days of his life." Picture his life, his commitment, his endurance, and his love for God and His people. How does Samuel's life challenge me as a follower of Christ?

Tuesday, April 28, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 8:1-9 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 8:1-3

- Tragically, Samuel's sons "did not walk in his ways. They turned aside after gain and took bribes and perverted justice." The Bible shows no clear pattern of godly parents producing godly children (e.g., Saul/Jonathan, David/Absalom). What can be concluded about Samuel's judgment at this point in his life from the fact that he "made his sons judges over Israel"?

1 Samuel 8:4-9

- What role did Samuel's sons play in Israel asking for a king "like all the nations"? What lessons can I learn from this?

1 Samuel 8:5

- The Israelites wanted a king so that they could be "like other nations." Reflect on the tragedy of this sentiment given the fact that their entire spiritual identity was that they were NOT like other nations, but rather a separate, called-out nation.

Leviticus 18:1-4 (ESV)

[1]And the LORD spoke to Moses, saying, [2]"Speak to the people of Israel and say to them, I am the LORD your God. [3]You shall not do as they do in the land of Egypt, where you lived, and you shall not do as they do in the land of Canaan, to which I am bringing you. You shall not walk in their statutes. [4]You shall follow my rules and keep my statutes and walk in them. I am the LORD your God."

Numbers 23:9 (ESV)

For from the top of the crags I see him,
from the hills I behold him;
behold, a people dwelling alone,
and not counting itself among the nations!

Psalm 106:35 (ESV)

but they mixed with the nations
and learned to do as they did.

Ezekiel 20:32 (ESV)

"What is in your mind shall never happen—the thought, 'Let us be like the nations, like the tribes of the countries, and worship wood and stone.'"

- To what degree have I embraced the call to be "called out," and therefore different, from the culture around me?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 8:4-22 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 8:10-19

- Why would the Israelites still insist on having a king after being warned that their king would enslave them?
- What are some worldly sources people look to for deliverance, even after warnings or disappointment?

1 Samuel 8:7, 21-22

- What insight does this provide about the world and how God interacts with human decisions and events?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:3-4 (ESV)

And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing. In their case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

Friday, May 1, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Monday, May 4, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 9:1-27 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 9:16

- Reflect on the fact that though the Israelites reject God by asking for a king (1 Samuel 8:7), God chooses a king for them, remains responsive to their cries, and continues to work out his will ("save my people from the hand of the Philistines") through the king.
- What hope does this give me in God's willingness and ability to work out his will in my life despite my many past failures, sins, and mistakes?
- Recall situations in which God has worked in this way in my life, and pray a prayer releasing past sins and failures, and affirming God's ongoing good work and guidance over my life.

1 Samuel 9:8-20

- Reflect on the fact that, in this chapter, Saul starts out on a mundane errand as a person of no standing. Yet, due to God's choice of him as king, Saul is anticipated as a special guest, treated with honor by Samuel, and given a new identity. In what ways do these events parallel the work of the Gospel in my life?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, May 5, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 10:1-13 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 10:1-11

- What can I learn about God from the way he assures Saul of his calling?
- Reflect on how God has “turned [me] into another man” (v. 6).

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 10:14-27 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 10:14-24

- How does Saul demonstrate his insecurity? Why is Saul's insecurity inappropriate?
- What has been my response to God's desire to use me?

1 Samuel 10:26-27

- Upon Saul's confirmation as king, two groups of people emerge. On what basis does the second group reject Saul, and what does this reveal about their view of God? What effect would they have had on others, on Saul, and on God's plan to deliver Israel from the Philistines through the new king?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 11:1-7 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 11:1-3

"The question that plagues the minds of the elders of Jabesh Gilead is whether there is anyone to deliver [NIV "rescue," ESV "save"] them [...] This passage is especially reminiscent of Judges 19-21. In the earlier tragic episode [...] when the tribes joined to take action against Benjamin [...] the inhabitants of Jabesh Gilead had not participated in the battles (Jud. 21:8). Reprisals were swift and severe (21:10-14). As a result, the inhabitants of the city probably have little reason now to hope that the tribes on the western side of the Jordan River will join together in order to defend them from the Ammonites."[6]

- Given the historical betrayal on the part of the people of Jabesh-gilead, what is notable about them sending out messengers throughout Israel?
- Are there ways I am reluctant to ask for help out of guilt from the past, or some complicated mixture of shame, awkwardness, expectation of rejection, or sense of resignation?

1 Samuel 11:1-7

- Contrast the two responses described in v. 4 and vv. 6-7.
- What can I learn from the fact that "they came out as one man" when "the dread of the LORD fell upon the people"?

6 Bill T. Wilson, NIV Application Commentary*: 1 & 2 Samuel (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2003), 175-85.*

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:5 (ESV)

For what we proclaim is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Monday, May 11, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 11:8-15 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- What can I learn about human nature from the people's reaction in v. 12?
- What can I learn from Saul's response?
- How did God use this seemingly bad situation with Nahash the Ammonite for Saul's good? What lesson can I learn about how to view challenges and difficulties?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, May 12, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 12:1-18 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 12:6-18

- What emotions were at play when the Israelites sought security outside of God?
- What was the crucial fact the Israelites forgot?
- What might be a modern-day Nahash for me and what do I need to do the next time I am confronted with such a situation?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 12:19-25 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 12:19-22

- What do we learn about God from this passage?

1 Samuel 12:20-25

- Reflect on Samuel's exhortations to the Israelites in this passage.

1 Samuel 12:23

- Reflect on Samuel's commitment to continue to pray for the people despite their repeated failures. In what ways have I been the recipient of this kind of commitment from God and from people that God has placed in my life?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Thursday, May 14, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 13:1-23 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 13:11-14

- It was a serious wrong for someone other than a priest to make burnt offerings. What drove Saul to do what he did? What does this reveal about Saul?
- What view of God do Saul's actions reveal?
- What do I need to cultivate in order to not find myself in the same place as Saul?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:6 (ESV)

For God, who said, "Let light shine out of darkness," has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Monday, May 18, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 14:1-23 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Read this text with the following themes in mind:
  - God's presence/absence
  - Bleak situations, obstacles
  - Faith
  - Few/many
  - True partnership
- What do I need to learn from Jonathan? From the armor-bearer?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, May 19, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 14:24-52 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- How did people suffer under Saul's impulsiveness?
- What warnings or lessons are there for me?
- What can I learn from the response of the men in v. 45?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Wednesday, May 20, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 15:1-31 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 15:9

- What aspect of Saul emerges from v. 9?

1 Samuel 15:10-12

- Reflect on the picture of God and Samuel grieving for Saul, and the picture of Saul "[setting] up a monument for himself." What explains this discrepancy?

1 Samuel 15:13-31

- Reflect on Saul's resistance to admitting the true reason for his disobedience. Why was he so reluctant?
- Reflect on the dissonance between v. 24 and v. 30.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 15:17-35 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 15:19-24

- What is the answer to Samuel's questions in v. 19?
- What might be the relationship between v.17 ("little in your own eyes") and v. 24 ("I feared the people"), and how do these themes work out in my life?

1 Samuel 15:34-35

- What is the significance of the prophet and king permanently separating?
- Reflect on Samuel and God's response to Saul (v. 35). Yet Saul has his own story. What warning does this have for me?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:7 (ESV)

But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 16:1-13 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

Samuel 16:1-4

- What lesson can I learn about the place of grieving and the need to take action to advance God's will?
- Is there some loss I am grieving or some discouragement I am dwelling on possibly to an inappropriate degree?

Samuel 16:6-7

"We often fail to see the God-potential in others (or in ourselves) because we are easily impressed by the wrong indicators. David, who will become the ideal anointed figure, is an unassuming sort when we first meet him. He would not have naturally attracted attention as a potential savior of his people. He is too young, too inexperienced, and too insignificant in his family's birth order. But David is also a precursor to one greater than he, to the Messiah, who also bore no especially striking physical characteristics:"[7]

> he had no form or majesty that we should look at him,
> and no beauty that we should desire him.
> He was despised and rejected by men,
> a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief;
> and as one from whom men hide their faces
> he was despised, and we esteemed him not. (Isa. 53:2b-3)

- Reflect on vv. 6-7. To what extent do I evaluate people based on external appearance or other such superficial features? How do these values play out in terms of how I see myself and others?

7 Bill T. Arnold, The NIV Application Commentary: 1 & 2 Samuel *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2003), 233.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, May 26, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 16:6-13 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Reflect on the words: "For the Lord sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart." How does this impact my life, on how I relate to God and to others?
- How can I cultivate this way of looking at myself and others?
- Considering that Jesse did not bother calling David to be present at the sacrifice, what assumption or bias caused Jesse to see David as an unlikely recipient of this anointing?
- Reflect on a time when God worked in my or another person's life in ways that went beyond my assumptions.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 16:14-23 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

"Actively, God never initiates or performs evil [...] Passively, God may withdraw the hand of His protection, and therefore allow evil to come, without being the source of the evil itself [...] This is indicated by what happened with Saul. First, the Spirit of the LORD departed from Saul. This meant Saul lost his spiritual 'protection' and covering. So, Satan was more than ready to send a distressing spirit to fill the void in Saul."[8]

- Reflect on the emotional state of Saul. After he fails to repent in Chapter 15, he's never the same again. Reflect on Psalm 32 in this light.

Psalm 32 (ESV), A Maskil Of David

1 Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven,
whose sin is covered.
2 Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity,
and in whose spirit there is no deceit.
3 For when I kept silent, my bones wasted away
through my groaning all day long.
4 For day and night your hand was heavy upon me;
my strength was dried up as by the heat of summer.
5 I acknowledged my sin to you,
and I did not cover my iniquity;
I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the LORD,"
and you forgave the iniquity of my sin.
6 Therefore let everyone who is godly
offer prayer to you at a time when you may be found;
surely in the rush of great waters,
they shall not reach him.
7 You are a hiding place for me;
you preserve me from trouble;
you surround me with shouts of deliverance.
8 I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go;
I will counsel you with my eye upon you.
9 Be not like a horse or a mule, without understanding,
which must be curbed with bit and bridle,
or it will not stay near you.
10 Many are the sorrows of the wicked,
but steadfast love surrounds the one who trusts in the LORD.
11 Be glad in the Lord, and rejoice, O righteous,
and shout for joy, all you upright in heart!

8 *David Guzik, "Commentary on 1 Samuel 16,"* David Guzik's Commentaries on the Bible, *1997-2003, http://www.studylight.org/com/guz/view.cgi?book=1sa&chapter=016.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 17:1-27 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 17:11

- Contrast Saul's response to Goliath to Saul's response to Nahash the Ammonite in chapter 11. What happened to Saul? What can I learn from this change?
- Recall the following words from the previous chapter: "But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not look on his appearance or on the height of his stature, because I have rejected him. For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart'" (1 Samuel 16:7). How does this theme of physical appearance play out in this chapter?
- How do I view people who are impressive in their abilities or accomplishments?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:8 (ESV)

We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair;

Friday, May 29, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 17:19-30 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Reflect on the contradiction between v. 20 and vv. 16, 24. What is the consequence of this gap between rhetoric ("war cry") and reality ("fled from him")?

1 Samuel 17:27-29

- David's brother rebukes him with an offensive slur on his character and motivation. What may have motivated such a sharp and unfair reaction? How do I respond to others when I am under stress or experiencing a 'shame storm'?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, June 2, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 17:31-40 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 17:34-37

- In what ways did David see the battle differently from Saul and the Israelites? What enabled David to be so confident in God's deliverance?
- Recall all the ways in which God has helped me grow in my trust in him. Based on God's faithfulness in his past dealings with me, in what areas can I learn to trust him more today?

1 Samuel 17:38-40

- David rejects the fine royal armor and chooses instead his staff, sling, and five smooth stones. What can I learn from this?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 17:41-58 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 17:41-58

- Think about why Goliath “disdained” David.

1 Samuel 17:45-47

- Meditate on David’s faith reflected in his words to Goliath. How does the fact that “the battle is the Lord’s” encourage me to take steps of faith in my struggle against my fears?
- In light of the story's end, what can I conclude about the theme of God's presence/absence during the 40 days of Goliath's taunts?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 18:1-11 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 18:1-4

- Contrast the basis of Jonathan's fondness of David with the usual reasons people feel fondness and closeness toward others.

1 Samuel 18:5-9

- In what ways do I keep a jealous eye on others, making me unable to celebrate what God has done in and/or through them?
- How is jealousy of others a rebellion toward God?
- How else might Saul have responded to David?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:9-10 (ESV)

persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed; always carrying in the body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our bodies.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 18:12-30 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 18:12-29

- Saul sees David as a threat and is therefore afraid of him. What perspective makes David a threat to Saul, and what perspective would make David a source of joy? What perspective do I have toward my brothers/sisters in Christ?
- What does Saul do with his fears, and what happens as a result? What does this teach me about the operation of fear?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 19:1-10 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Even though Saul agreed with Jonathan's reasoning and even took an oath, his later actions expose the insanity of his jealousy. How does this demonstrate the inadequacy of mere reasoning to uproot deeper sins of the heart?
- What drives people to take actions that defy what they know to be right and just?
- What can I learn about the strength of harbored sins and how I should deal with them?
- Is there some entrenched sin—jealousy, bitterness, resentment, or other stronghold—that I need to deal with more seriously than I have been?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 19:11-24 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 19:14-17

- Starting with Jonathan, and now Michal, Saul starts to lose his own family members. What warning does this give to me regarding what happens to a person who insists on acting out of jealousy or insecurity?

1 Samuel 19:18-24

"Finally, Saul must go himself (v.22); no one can do his dirty work for him. Before he even reaches the place where David and Samuel are, he is also seized by the Spirit of God (v.23). He falls into the same ecstatic frenzy as the others while apparently continuing to Naioth in Ramah. When there, he strips off his clothes and falls on the ground before Samuel and lies naked for an entire day and night. It is a scene of Saul's final and total humiliation and his complete loss of authority as God's anointed king. Before God's prophet, the spirit of God, which once authorized him (10:9-10), now leaves Saul naked, prostrate, humiliated, and powerless. David then makes good his escape."[9]

- What can I learn from David's decision to first go to Samuel in his time of fear and distress?
- What should Saul have recognized after "the Spirit of God came upon the messengers of Saul" for the third time? In what ways do people ignore God's intervention while in pursuit of their personal agenda, and end up bringing shame upon their life?

9 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1128.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 20:1-42 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 20:14-17

- What does Jonathan's request to David reveal about what he believed about David's future? How would this have strengthened David at this point in his life?
- Reflect on Jonathan's relationship with David. In what ways can I learn to take more initiative in my relationships and become a source of encouragement and vision for my friends?

1 Samuel 20:30-34

- What warning does Saul's anger toward Jonathan give me regarding my response when people do not agree with or cooperate with me?

1 Samuel 20:31, 35-42

- Reflect once again on Jonathan's character, considering what Saul says (accurately) in v. 31. What must have been Jonathan's view of God, history, and himself? How does this compare with how I view these issues?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:11-12 (ESV)

For we who live are always being given over to death for Jesus' sake, so that the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our mortal flesh. So death is at work in us, but life in you.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Monday, June 15, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 21:1-15 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Think about how David's life has been after he was anointed by Samuel (chapter 16). What lesson can I learn from this?
- Spend some time reflecting on how God has helped me to grow through difficulties or long delays in the past. What might God be teaching me through difficult circumstances today?
- While the situation may have appeared bleak, in what ways did God provide for David? How have I experienced God's timely provisions during difficulties?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 22:1-5 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

"We cannot read this notice in 1 Sam 22:2 about David's attracting to himself the outcasts of the land without remembering that Jesus, the son of David, also attracted the outcasts of his time. There is a word about the nature of God's kingdom as opposed to human kingdoms here. God's kingdom does not find its membership in the usual patterns of power and influence. It is often 'the least of these' who become significant, and the 'last will become first.' David is clear in the midst of the mundane concerns of these verses that his kingdom will be a result of what 'God will do for me.' It will not be of his own making."[10]

- What can I learn from the fact that those who gathered around David were "everyone who was in distress, and everyone who was in debt, and everyone who was bitter in soul"?
- Reflect on the things David had to do during this time when he was on the run (chapter 21). How was God shaping David during this time as Israel's future king? What perspective does this give me regarding times of personal difficulty and uncertainty?
- What can I learn about David's faith in God during this uncertain time from the statement, "till I know what God will do for me"?

10 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1145.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 22:6-19 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 22:6-8

"Saul's madness seems to have taken a paranoid turn. He imagines that Jonathan's commitment to David is a plot to ambush him, and he accuses his own men of knowing about this. This must have seemed outrageous and unwarranted to Saul's men. In the text, they remain speechless."[11]

- Why does it make sense that Saul—who has wronged David, rejected God, and refused to adjust to reality—winds up becoming paranoid?

1 Samuel 22:9-16

- Why would Saul (tragically) reject the very reasonable and plausible explanation of Ahimelech regarding his innocent provision for David?
- When I am faced with circumstances that cause me to suspect something, how ready am I to reject my own theory and believe the reasonable explanation of others?
- Which do I want to avoid more: being 'duped' or believing something false about someone?

11 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1147.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 22:17-23 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 22:17-19

- Contrast Doeg the Edomite with the king's officials who "would not put out their hand to strike the priests of the LORD." What kind of person was Doeg the Edomite?
- Reflect on the progression of Saul's jealousy towards David and the destruction it produced.

1 Samuel 22:20-23

"In this story, David models what is required in the face of evil. David takes responsibility for what has come to pass and moves on toward God's future. The violence was Saul's, but it is David who says, "I am responsible." The priests of Nob are tragically gone, but Abiathar can be sheltered, and a different kingdom from Saul's can be brought into being."[12]

- What can I learn about David from his response to Abiathar?

12 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1149.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:13-14 (ESV)

Since we have the same spirit of faith according to what has been written, "I believed, and so I spoke," we also believe, and so we also speak, knowing that he who raised the Lord Jesus will raise us also with Jesus and bring us with you into his presence.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 23:1-14 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 23:1-12

- Given David's men's initial response and Saul's statement, "he has shut himself in by entering a town that has gates and bars," what must have been the military advisability of rescuing Keilah from the Philistines?
- What is remarkable about David's concern for Keilah?
- What can I learn from the fact that God tells David to go and rescue Keilah even while David is on the run?

1 Samuel 23:7

- How is it possible for Saul to think that God is on his side in handing David over to him? What is at the root of this kind of self-deception?

Monday, June 22, 2026

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 23:12-29 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 23:12-18

- How might David have felt upon hearing that the citizens of Keilah would surrender him to Saul, and that he would once again be on the run?
- Think about the specific words Jonathan speaks to David. What picture of encouragement can I find in this text?

1 Samuel 23:22-29

- How does this passage show that God is in control?
- Are there some temptations or difficulties I am facing right now where I need to trust God (cf. 1 Cor 10:13)?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 24:1-7 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- What about David's personality is revealed from the fact that, though he did not intend to harm Saul, he still "stealthily cut off a corner of Saul's robe"?
- Reflect on David's amazing self-restraint. What non-negotiable principle must David have already adopted to be able to make such a quick and firm decision at a time when circumstances and the advice of his men seemed to all point in one direction?
- What spiritual and ethical non-negotiables have I adopted to guide me during pressing times when persuasive-sounding arguments and opportune circumstances can lead me astray?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 24:8-22 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- What can I learn from David's speech to Saul?
- Despite his remorseful response to David, Saul later ends up hunting for David once again. In what ways do I respond with the right words or emotions to truths about myself, yet remain unchanged?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:15 (ESV)

For it is all for your sake, so that as grace extends to more and more people it may increase thanksgiving, to the glory of God.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 25:1-44 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 25:1-3, 17, 25, 36

"In the wilderness of Judah, the dangers to flocks from predators and thieves were quite real, but with David's men there, no sheep had been lost (even to David's men). Nabal's shepherds seem to believe that the presence and protection of David's men is an asset. David himself seems to believe that a genuine service had been rendered (v.21). Certainly David's request seems respectful rather than demanding..."[13]

- Nabal's folly might have been mitigated had he not been someone that "one cannot speak to." How easy is it for people to talk to me about my character issues or blind spots?

1 Samuel 25:26-34

- What lessons can I learn from what Abigail says to David?
- What can I learn from David's response to Abigail? Do I have the humility to abandon my course based on this kind of intervention?

13 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1166-67.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 26:1-25 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 26:1-12

- Picture David hatching the plan to sneak into a camp of 3,000 enemy soldiers and then turning to the two men and saying, "Who will go down into the camp with me to Saul?" What can I infer from this incident about the kind of leader he must have been?
- Although Abishai's advice to David seemed logical, what can I learn from David's response? What does this say regarding the importance of having a preset stance to be able to make a strong moral decision, even against the advice of those close to me?

1 Samuel 26:17-21

- Saul seems once again genuinely touched by David's restraint and impressed deeply with the inevitability of David's ultimate triumph. Yet he seems unable to act—namely, to surrender the throne—based on what he knows and feels deeply. What warnings or lessons can I learn from this?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Wednesday, July 1, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 27:1-12 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- What are some words from v. 1 that tip us off to the source of David's poor decision in fleeing to the Philistines?
- What is the irony of this after even his own enemy Saul blesses him (1 Samuel 26:25 - "Blessed be you, my son David! You will do many things and will succeed in them")?
- What warning do I need to heed from this story?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 28:1-25 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 28:1-7

"The Saul of this story is sad and pathetic – a despairing, beaten man. His energy is not spent facing crisis and giving leadership in what must have been a terrifying moment for all of Israel. Instead of facing his destiny, he is still seeking ways to know and control his destiny. In desperation, he turns to idolatrous practices. In fear of the future, he returns to a past that cannot save him."[14]

- Review how Saul was portrayed in 1 Samuel 11:1-11 and 1 Samuel 14:47-48 and then consider his reaction here in v. 5. What is the relationship between Saul's jealousy over David and the loss of the courage he once had as a valiant warrior? What is the source of true courage?
- What can I learn about Saul (and human nature) from the fact that it was he who had expelled the mediums and spiritists from the land and yet he is now turning to one out of desperation?
- Are there illegitimate things that I turn to when I am overcome with fear and God seems to be silent?

14 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1185.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:16 (ESV)

So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 29:1-11 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

"This chapter is a continuation of 27:1-28:2. David had offered himself and his men in service to Achish the king of Gath and had been given Ziklag as an outpost for keeping the enemies of Gath pacified and enriching the coffers of Achish. Although David had launched campaigns against the traditional enemies of Judah, he had fooled Achish into thinking he was raiding his own people. In 28:1-2, David was placed in an awkward position by being called out to join Philistine forces in a campaign against Israel. We were left in suspense while the scene shifted to Saul's meeting with Samuel's ghost in 28:3-25. This episode tells us how David was saved from the politically disastrous position of doing battle against Israel."[15]

- What kind of dilemma did David's shrewd manipulation of his enemies get him into?
- Reflect on how this entire distasteful chapter of David's life began. What lesson about trusting in God can I learn from this?

15 Thomas B. Dozeman, The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1185.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, July 7, 2026

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 30:1-10 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

- Why would David's men think of stoning their leader when it was the Amalekites who carried off their families? What can I learn about human nature from this incident?
- Have there been times when I blamed others or became irrational because I was "greatly distressed" and "bitter in soul"?
- Contrast their response to the way David handles this situation.

Journal

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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 30:11-31 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 30:21-25

- What is the worldview of "the wicked and worthless fellows" who did not want to share the plunder with those who were "too exhausted" to continue to the battle?
- Contrast their response to David's response in vv. 23-24. What is behind their different responses?
- Whose attitude can I relate to more? Do I hold to a view of 'fairness' that says people should get what they deserve?

Journal

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- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: 1 Samuel 31:1-13 (ESV)

Reflection & Application

1 Samuel 31:1-3

- Reflect on God's hand in David's life in helping him remain blameless towards Saul till the end. What can I learn about God from the fact that he spared David from being part of this battle that is responsible for killing Saul and his sons, including Jonathan?

1 Samuel 31:1-10

"In the previous unit, God's guidance for David was both defensive and offensive. He intervened in David's dealings with Achish and the Philistines to prevent him from fighting against Israel, but he also intervened against the Amalekites to provide a much-needed military victory. By contrast, Saul is quickly turned over to the Philistines and decapitated after his death, and his body is left exposed to the elements. Saul failed to accept Yahweh as king, so Yahweh rejected Saul as king. Future anointed ones should be like David, not like Saul."[16]

- After years of rejecting God as king, Saul finally comes to a tragic end. What are the crucial steps that Saul took that led to this outcome of his life?
- How did Saul's undignified death bring shame not only to his name but also to God's name (vv. 9-10)?

1 Samuel 31:11-13

"The final word of this chapter is not, however, of death and humiliation but of honor [...] The people of Jabesh-gilead could not forget or ignore the debt they owe Saul for his swift and valiant rescue when they were at the mercy of Nahash, the king of Ammon (chap. 11). Saul had begun his time as king with courageous and effective leadership as befits a king. For the people of Jabesh-gilead, this moment remains worthy of honor, and they act to ensure that this honor be bestowed even in death. Saul is not to have a place in Israel's future, but the people of Jabesh-gilead ensure that Saul's royal moments in Israel's past will be remembered."[17]

- What can I learn from the people of Jabesh-gilead about the proper place of gratitude and honor toward people based on their past conduct, even if their later conduct is not worthy of honor?

16 *Bill T. Arnold,* The NIV Application Commentary*: 1 & 2 Samuel (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2003), 402.*
17 *Thomas B. Dozeman,* The New Interpreter's Bible, *Abingdon Press (Nashville, 1998), 2:1198.*

Journal

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- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

2 Corinthians 4:17-18 (ESV)

For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison, as we look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen. For the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.

1 SAMUEL 15:22

Has the Lord as great delight in burnt
offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying
the voice of the Lord?
Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice,
and to listen than the fat of rams.